What Gandhiji said on Cow and Cow Protection

(From his Collected Works)

PLACE OF THE COW

[…] She is the mother to millions of Indian mankind. Protection of the cow means protection of the whole dumb creation of God […]

I worship it and I shall defend its worship against the whole world.

THE COW IN HINDUISM

The central fact of Hinduism is cow protection. […] Cow protection to me is one of the most wonderful phenomena in human evolution. It takes the human being beyond this species. The cow to me means the entire sub-human world […] Cow protection is the gift of Hinduism to the world. And Hinduism will live so long as there are Hindus to protect the cow

COW-SLAUGHTER

Cow protection to me is not mere protection of the cow […] Cow-slaughter and man-slaughter are in my opinion the two sides of the same coin.

Gandhi's quotes on the cow were specific to the anti-imperial context they were uttered in. But the recourse to Gandhi was yet another tool to reinforce the BJP's positioning on this issue. It was illustrative of how clear the BJP has long been about where it stands on its core issues: issues of identity politics symbolised by issues like cow protection, its commitment to a Ram Temple, or the idea of a strong nationalist state with a tough posture on terrorism and national security.

The narrative of the 'tukde-tukde' gang, or the nationwide agitation around the Citizenship Amendment Bill, or the aggressive 'desh ke gaddaron ko, golee maaro saalon ko' (traitors to the nation, shoot those scoundrels) sloganeering by a Union minister in 2020—such ideological wedge issues have been the front edge of the